Learning To Walk: Part One: Hitching Up the Carriage

“Come on lets get this on the road before your legs quit on us. I’ll bet your tired but I want to make sure you can do a lap or two before we quit for the night. If you can do that the party tomorrow will be cake for you,” Her kind smile lit up the whole room.
furrowing my brow my head tilted on autopilot.
“Lap? If we are going for a run I’ll need to put my other shoes back on.”
She giggled.
“No we’re just doing a loop or two around the halls. We’ll be walking I promise. One of us will even be walking forward,” she winked at me. Gulping I looked at her with wide eyes.
“Am I the one going forward. Right? If I’m not we might want to call the ambulance now!”
“Yep you’re the driver. I’ll be the horse,”
“You’ll be the What?!”
She laughed.
“My cousin and I used to do this. We called it Taking the Reins.
Its pretty simple. You ever drove a carriage?”

“Oh yeah all the time. When my civic is in the shop I hook up the horse and that’s how I get to work. What the hell are you talking about?”

She open the door and ushered me out. “After you my lady,”
The small gesture and others like it, her honest tenderness or the things she said I found funny kept a smile plastered across my face.
(She’s just being nice don’t read to much into it dumbass.)

Stepping in front of me she began to explain.
“Think of this as a dance,”
“I don’t know how to danced either.”

Head drooping she groaned.
“That’s another lesson for another time. I doubt there will be any dancing going on at this thing. We won’t worry about that bridge until we have to. Doesn’t matter for now. This is simple. Here is how it works. We start out facing each other like we are. You take my left hand in your right.” She held out her hand to me. Wrapped mine hers she felt so warm and soft. My breath hitch.
Looking at me, she smiled. “Hey there pretty eyes.”
My cheeks felt so warm.
Pulling in a deep breath, my eyes found hers.
“Yep I’m good. So now what.”
“Oh… um… me too… Now you take my right hand into your left.” Reaching over she wrapped my left hand with her right.

(Rachel what is this insane harlot doing to you?)
[How the hell would I know?]

“OK now I Need you to trust me a little bit.”
I blinked.

“Rachel?”
“I’m thinking about that?”
She laughed.
“Just trust me. You’ll be fine. I Promise.”
Taking a long breath I gave her a nod and a smile.
“OK.”

“Good. Here is the fun part. I’m gonna be the one walking backwards and you’re gonna drive.”
“I”m gonna do what?”
Her laugh filled the hall and her smile gleamed in with the halls fairy light decorations. It’s not hard you’re going steer my like I’m a carriage. The way you that is is simple. If I need to go to your right you pull your right hand to your body. If I need to go left you pull your left hand to your body. The closer you pull it to your body the more I’ll turn. To make me go faster just push a little bit on both my hands to make me stop pull them to you pull both your hands to your body like this to get me to stop.”
She steeped closer, pushing my hands against my body.
I wondered if she could feel me shivering.
Make sense?”

My eyes felt the size of watermelons.

(She’s actually crazy! See I told you she was a problem.) I couldn’t disagree.
“Yes and totally not at all. The how is super clear the why isn’t at all,”
Shaking her head she laughed.
“You can use the practice and it keeps me near you if you have an issue,”

“But you/re gonna get killed !” I yelped.
With a long sigh she released my hands, and she took a step closer to me. I could smell her rose perfume and her peppermint breath. Holding my eyes in hers and lifted her hand to my face. Then she did something brand new, I’d never seen except in moves. Placing her hand on my jaw and slid her thumb slowly over my cheek.
“Rachel, I’m never gonna let anything happen to you.”
My breath stopped and a tremble settled in hands she had in hers.
With a smile she squeezed my hands. “Rachel, it’s OK. I trust you.”
“I wouldn’t!”
She laughed.
“OK Lilly, I trust you too,”

“Whatever happens next to us both is completely in our hands. But the choice of where we go from here is all yours. You’re driving and you’re the one in charge. I’m the one with the experience. I know how fast I’m comfortable with. That’s our speed limit. Beyond that it’s up to you. I’ll never want you to go faster than you can handle. If you want to stop at any point just pull me tight too you and I’ll stop

with you. It doesn't matter what we are doing. I never want to make you feel rushed or forced into anything you don't feel comfortable with. OK?"

I gulped and my breathing shallowed. We stood there in each others eyes while I held her hands in my. Neither of us moved. I see her breathing and felt it in my hands. A door lock clicked down the hall breaking it for us.

(Oh my god! Rachel got get a cot! Stop this right now!)

[Leave me a lone for second I'm trying to concentrate on this lesson.]
"Are you still wanting to do this with me?" she asked.

Slowly I nodded.

(Rachel! Are you insane?)

[Well if we are keeping score. I have a little voice in my head that I talk to. So the answer to that question seems pretty obvious.]

She smiled at me then glanced over her shoulder.
"OK, are you ready?"
"Nope"
"Good lets go,"
With that she took a step backwards in her 6 inch heels.
I match by stepping forward.
"OK so I can't see and your my eyes, so give it a try to get used to how I move,"

Wide eyed I pull my left hand in and sure enough she turned us left and I tried the same with her right with the same results and we began our trip for real.

She held my eyes without looking backwards kat all. "So tell me more about Niomi. Why don't you use that name?"

"Uh… what?"

She giggled. "Come on give it up!"
"Oh ok. Um I started using it in grade school. I person used it once and it brings up bad memories. So I quit using it for anything except legal stuff. My brother and Debbie call me Rach or Rachel. Ron mostly call me asshole,"

"Oh so you two don't get along?"

I burst into laughter.
"Not from the outside I'm sure it looks like we don't he the best guy I know. Just please don't tell him I

said that,"
She giggle. "It's just between us,"
"So what about you what the hell is up with this. How in th hell are you able to do this?"
I pulled her arm and maneuvered us around a food cart in the hall way.
"Oh way to many beauty pageants,"
Knitting my brow I leaned to check the hall behind her.
"beauty pageants?"
She smiled and we kept going backwards.
"Yeah, mom was the one who was into that so I got to be in every one she could enter me in. I think she meant well it was never really something I enjoyed. If I ever had a daughter I don't think I'd force them or much of anything else on her. Mom kept me in them till I got old enough to stop. I even won a few,"
"I'm sure it was more than a few!" I felt that came out a little more enthusiastic than It should have.
Chuckling she smile. "Let me see. When I was a kid around 12 Miss Hub City, 13 Miss Brooking's Teen, 14 Miss Rapid City Teen, 15 Miss Siouxland Runner up. My cousin beat me on that. She's so much prettier than me,"

"I doubt that! Your gorgeous!" (Rachel!)

She laughed "I'm just me. I really didn't care much honestly. Guess what my talent was?"

I check behind her and then I shook my head "No idea,"

With a giggle she smiled "Walking backward in heels. That was my big talent. Honestly I wasn't something I would have done without my mom pushing me into it. I hated it. You'd be in the dressing room with people watching. Sometimes men who had no business being in the dressing room of young girls. And you always wondered If another girl was prettier than you. The competition is fierce. You can't make friends at all. Don't get me wrong. Competition wasn't the issue I just didn't' like that it was competing over my looks. Not much I can do about that. That's why once I was old enough I barrel raced. Now that I'm a whole different way to compete." her eyes meed to sparkle a bit when she said it. That was my daddy's doing. My was the beauty queen but daddy he's the rancher. We breed rodeo horses. Well his ranch does. Mine has cows, chickens and pigs but that's about it. Daddy's got about 1000 acres. I only got 250 so mine is pretty small but they are side by side. The Red Tail office sets on his, He's a half owner in so makes sense,"

My mouth fell open. "Wait you're a beauty queen and barrel racer, and you own ranch with 200 acres?"

She laughed "Yeah I got a few championship buckles from barrel racing around the country. At one point I thought about going pro but life happens and it's pretty rough on yah. I quit after I lost at Cheyenne," Miss Penny, She'd gotten up there by then but she really needed a better rider. But I realized it gotten to let her live the good life on Daddy's farm. Together weren't gonna hack it, on a pro circuit. I was gonna try again with shadow but …" She trailed off… and I saw her eyes get glass for a

moment then she sniffled.
“Away I haven’t raced in 7 years or so,”

“So tell me about your Daddy. Sounds like you two are pretty close,”

Chuckling she smile and the forming tears seemed to had disappeared.
“Oh he is a character for sure. He’s he’s an instigator. He built the ranch up from 100 acres. Used to be an Engineer at NASA. Worked on the shuttle program. But a few years after Challenger he quit said he couldn’t after that he couldn’t deal with it any more, so he bought the land and stated raisin cattle then got into horses and Rodeo stuff. His brother had the idea to idea for Retailed Consultants and daddy put up the farm as collateral. Now we’ve been profitable for while now. I just do sales. Nathan and Heather are the real stars of the show, there. ”

Shaking my head I check around her just in time to pull her hard left. The old man who we nearly hit with the bag and his wife stepped out of their door I pull Lilly hard to keep her from crashing into her. As we went by I realized the couple had been the same one from the airport when I’d gotten to Ohio. The same women who the bag had hit an the ones it’d nearly got on our run to the room and we had nearly hit them again.

“What the hell are you girls doing! Stop that or you’re gonna kill somebody!”
I looked at Lilly whose green eyes were the size of a saucer.
I cracked up.
“Yes sir!” she shouted.

Taking a glance over my shoulder I yelled
“Merry Christmas!”

“Let’s call it a night before we really do get somebody hurt” I
She nodded pulled me for a connecting hallway that lead to ours. Slowing her down according to the instructions he gave me we came to a stop and she released me.
“Your a natural!”
My whole body trembled. My calves were feeling a burn I’d not known for years. “Damn, I need to get my ass off the couch more.”

She laughed. “Come work on my ranch for a few weeks.”

It made me chuckle, but she held her eyes on me.

I threw my arms around her and pulled her tight. “Thank you!”

A long sigh came from her, and I felt her pulling me tighter to her.

We didn’t speak. Just two women in a hallway embraced in a hug. One I’d started, and neither of us was letting go. I didn’t care. She felt so warm in my arms. And her perpetual rogue of peppermint and rose coming from her was quickly replacing my idea of what heaven smelled like.

“Oh look at them, they look so lovely, don’t they!” Looking over my shoulder, I saw the elderly couple walking by. Easing up, I looked at her and she looked at me. We began to giggle. But in a moment it died away. She hadn’t left my arms, but I’d become lost in her eyes. Her chest moved in a ragged rhythm in time with my own.

A stray hair had fallen into her eyes. Moving my hand to it, I tucked it back, but my other stayed wrapped around her, resting at the small of her back. The free hand stroked her cheek.

“Thank you,” I whispered.

She nodded with a smile. “Anytime.”

The whole world seemed to be vibrating.

I don’t know how to do it. What if I suck at it? What if I’m misreading everything? What if she thinks I’m...

(*Rachel, release her now!*)

I jumped and let go.

Lilly deflated like I’d pulled an invisible plug somewhere.

[*You see what you did, you fucking bitch!*]

(*I didn’t do that, you were the one leading her on!*)

[*I wasn’t leading her on.*]

(*What do you mean?*)

[*You know exactly what I mean cause you're in my fucking head!*]

(*You’re toying with dark forces here.*)

Slowly she pulled away, and I wanted to pull her back, but I didn’t.

“It’s getting pretty late. I’d like to turn in and you got the key. Would you mind?”

“Oh, um yeah. Sorry.”

Slowly we started making our way back towards the room in silence.

(*You’re lucky I was here to stop you from that big mistake you almost made.*)

Fuck you! I screamed at the voice silently! *What the fuck difference does it make to you!*

(*None. If you want to burn in hell like she said you would, go for it.*)

[*I don’t give a fuck anymore! I was … shut the fuck up and leave me alone for once and let me have something!*]

Her eyes were looking at the carpet as we walked along.

“Lilly, please stop. Please!” and she did.

I stepped in front of her.

I took as deep of a breath as I could find.

“I don’t know if I … Look, I don’t know how… It’s new… Um… the.. Ah, shoes, I mean… They aren’t the type of shoe I ever considered wearing before.”

Raising her head, she looked at me with a knitted brow.

I waited for her to say something. She nodded, and a grin gently tugged at the corners of her mouth. “Is that the issue? Or is it me?”

Looking into her eyes, I shook my head. “I promise you this is a me thing… Since I’ve met you, I’ve been thinking that I’ve missed out on a lot of things. Walking in the wrong kind of shoes has been the main thing I’ve been wondering about. Like it’s been on my mind ever since you took off with my bag. I’ve been too afraid to admit it to myself.”

Nodding, the grin grew.

“So, legit, it really is brand new to you?”

Nodding, I let out a long sigh. “Yeah, it is… I’m sorry if I made it seem like I knew what I was doing... It’s a new way of walking for me. It's nothing I’ve even let myself think about doing before… Walking in these kinds of shoes, I mean. I thought I was supposed to walk in the same kind of shoes as everyone else did.”

“Oh, I gotcha. I’m sorry… I really thought you knew what kind of shoes you like to walk in. God, I’m so sorry. You need to walk the way you want to.” Her head drooped. She took a step towards the door.

“No!” I yelped.

She stopped. Her head tilted. “What do you mean, no?”

“I’m fucking all this up. What I’m trying to tell you is I want to. I just need a good teacher. Someone kind and gentle. Someone who’d be willing to show me how. I really want you to teach me if you are willing. Please. If you don’t want to, I understand. It’s a lot to ask of you. I’m not even sure I’m looking for a casual stroll or a lifelong walk yet cause the idea is still new to me. But whatever it is, I would like to be taught how to walk in these kinds of shoes by you.”

Her smile beamed and she nodded her head. “That’s why you don’t need to rush, and we’ll walk as fast or slow as you want to. Is that OK?”

I nodded and threw my arms around her. “God, thank you!” I whispered into her ear.

I felt her sigh. “Thank you for telling me that. It’s gonna be OK, Rachel. I promise.”

I squeezed her tight.